PAKISTAN ARMY CHIEFS: THE

A COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF THE ARMY CHIEFS WHO WIELDED SIGNIF



GENERAL AYUB KHAN
(1958–1969)

After a coup against President Iskander Mirza, Ayub, as army chief, imposed Pakistan's first martial law. He centralised power, pushed for secular modernisation with a "controlled democracy". He advocated state-guided capitalism, achieving fast growth but worsening inequality. Unleashed the 1965 war against India, which is seen as inconclusive.



GENERAL ZIA-UL-HAQ
(1977–1988)

After overthrowing Zulfikar Ali Bhutto in a coup, Zia Islamicised Pakistan's polity and military, and wove Islamic law into governance. His economic model relied on foreign aid, mainly from the US and Saudi Arabia. In return, he nurtured a jihadist infrastructure to thwart the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan. Ties with India remained hostile.



GENERAL PERVEZ MUSHARRAF
(1999–2008)

The mastermind of the Kargil War, Musharraf came to power overthrowing PM Nawaz Sharif and sought to moderate Pakistan's Islamic identity. He pushed for growth through privatisation and foreign investment, but failed to reform structurally. He pivoted Pakistan as a key US ally after 9/11, pursued peace with India.



GENERAL ASHFAQ PARVEZ KAYANI
(2007–2013)

The 2008 Mumbai terror attacks were sanctioned on Kayani's watch but after that, he withdrew the army from overt politics, preferring behind-the-scenes influence instead. His focus was on professionalising the army and moving from an India-centric defence towards counter-terrorism in Swat and Waziristan.

has gone beyond being just the security czar of Pakistan, and now controls all levers of political power, including tackling Pakistan's distressed economy through the army-manned Special Investment Facilitation Council. Munir has also adroitly 'cleansed' the Supreme Court of Imran backers by getting an amendment passed in Parliament that allows the supersession of judges. In one more unprecedented move, he got another amendment passed in Parliament that extended his three-year tenure to five. This has ensured he will be in the driver's seat till 2027, with no age limit for another extension.

"It's pretty telling the way Munir has handled the polycrisis he confronted after he became chief," says Michael Kugelman, a South Asian analyst based in the US. "There was severe political instability, the economy was on the verge of collapse, there was resurgent terrorism and a marked internal dissent in the army. He has addressed those problems better than others and has kept things under control. He has his failures, but in terms of his actions, Munir is resolute and exhibits a supreme level of confidence in the way he has inserted himself in so many different aspects of public policy." But even as the army chief has consolidated his position in the institutional space, there have been real-world setbacks on the security front, particularly the recent hijacking of Jaffar Express by Baloch rebels, which have dented his and the army's credibility. There is also growing discontent among Pakistan's youth, who are unhappy with the way the country is being run.

The Pakistan army has always played an outsize role in running the country—in the 77 years of its existence, the country has been under martial law for 33 years, in three different phases. Munir, though, has emerged as one of the most powerful army chiefs in recent times without having to topple the civilian dispensation. He is the first army chief after General Zia-ul-Haq to invoke Islamist nationalism and even wear it as a badge of honour. In fact, he holds the